

Compare and Contrast - Study Guide

Compare people, events, ideas, and methods on the same basis - then notice why the difference matters.

Learning goal

Identify meaningful similarities and differences, avoid surface-level comparisons, and explain how a contrast develops the text.

Compare on the same basis

A useful comparison asks the same question about both things. If you compare two programs, you might compare cost with cost, goal with goal, method with method, or result with result. A weak answer often mixes categories - for example, the cost of one program with the purpose of the other.

A similarity is more than sharing a topic. Two proposals can both discuss transportation but recommend opposite actions. A difference matters when it helps explain a result, a choice, a viewpoint, or the writer's larger point.

Task	Strong thinking	Weak thinking
Similarity	Both methods reduce water use by changing when irrigation occurs.	Both are about gardens.
Difference	Method A requires staff supervision; Method B can run automatically.	One paragraph is longer.
Significance	The automation difference explains why Method B costs more at first but less to operate.	They are different in some ways.

Question language to recognize

- How are ____ and ____ similar?
- What is one important difference between ____ and ____?
- How does ____ contrast with ____?

- Why does the author compare ____ with ____?

A reliable method

- 1 Name the two things being compared.
- 2 Choose one comparison category: goal, method, evidence, attitude, result, cost, or effect.
- 3 Write a two-column note with one short phrase for each side.
- 4 Select the option that compares the same category and is supported by both sides.

Fast scratch note

A: ____ | B: ____ . Keep both notes on the same category. If one side says "cost" and the other says "purpose," restart the comparison.

Worked example

Example

Two libraries tested ways to reduce noise. Library A created a separate quiet floor and kept group rooms unchanged. Library B added sound-absorbing panels throughout the building but did not create a separate quiet area. Surveys showed that both approaches reduced complaints, though Library A received more requests for additional group rooms.

1. How are the two approaches similar?

- A. Both create a separate quiet floor
- B. Both change the building in ways intended to reduce noise
- C. Both remove group rooms
- D. Both receive identical survey feedback

Answer: B

Both libraries make a physical/space change to reduce noise. The specific methods are different.

Common traps

- A shared topic that is not a meaningful similarity.
- A real difference that has nothing to do with the question.
- Reversing which person or method has which feature.
- Comparing unlike categories, such as one side's goal with the other side's result.

Quick check

Mini text

Two student teams tracked cafeteria waste. Team 1 weighed all discarded food at the end of lunch. Team 2 photographed trays at several points during lunch and estimated the amount discarded. Both teams found that waste was highest on days when a new menu item was introduced.

1. What is an important difference between the teams?

- A. They studied different cafeterias
- B. They used different methods to measure waste
- C. Only one team found higher waste on new-menu days
- D. Only one team studied food waste

Answer: B. The goal and finding are similar, but the measurement methods differ.

Diagnostic help

Use the mistake pattern to decide what to change on your next question.

1

If: You compare different features of the two subjects.

Try: Name one category first - cost, purpose, method, result - and compare both subjects on that same category.

2

If: You pick a detail that is true for only one side.

Try: A comparison answer must accurately describe the relationship between both sides, not merely repeat one detail.

3

If: You treat a partial similarity as if the subjects are identical.

Try: Check the degree of similarity. Strong answers preserve important differences instead of flattening them.

30-second reset

Before the next compare & contrast question: restate the target, point to the evidence, and reject any choice that needs an extra assumption.